



rests. At the same time, the chief minister dispatched a team to West Bengal that studied and reported back that Andhra Pradesh was more serious in its implementation of land reforms than the Marxists. The Government also accepted 74 of the 104 recommendations of the Ranga Rao panel while the other suggestions were still being considered.

The Communist agitation meanwhile, intensified. The state secretaries of the two parties—B.V. Raghavulu of CPI(M) and K. Narayana of CPI—began an indefinite hunger strike on July 22. But when Reddy made it abundantly clear that the Government will not cave in to the pressure tactics, the Left parties called for the bandh that turned bloody on July 28. Now they are threatening to intensify the agitation and demanding that there should be an independent land commission at the

TROUBLE-TRIGGER

- CPI and CPI(M) launch the Bhu Poratam jointly on May 2 to distribute surplus land to the poor.
- On July 28, seven are killed in police firing on Marxist agitators.
- Police register 16 thousand cases against protestors.
- Government declares grant of Rs 5 lakh along with land and a job for the family of each of those killed.
- The CPI(M) asks for Reddy's resignation and is joined by TDP; CPI feels otherwise.
- High command directs Reddy to carry the Communists with the Congress in the state.

COLD COMFORT: Families of those killed in the police firing have been offered jobs by Reddy

state level to keep track of the distribution of land to the poor and similar committees at the district level with joint collectors as chairpersons. Along with the creation of a separate court for dealing with land disputes pending for the past 35 years, a ministry should be created exclusively for land distribution, a separate bench of the High Court for dealing with disputes on land administration and publication of a white paper on the extent of land available and how much of it has been distributed.

"This is the biggest social issue on which not only political parties but also the people are agitating and we are supporting it," says TDP President N. Chandrababu Naidu, who has also demanded the resignation of the chief minister by describing him as "a dictator". TDP has also realised that backing the demand for distribution of the land and houses for the poor is likely to help it win supporters and, therefore, wants Reddy to step down after owing responsibility for the police firing.

Disturbed by the developments in the state, the central leadership of the Communist parties, has intensified its campaign against the Reddy Government. "We don't care if he stays or goes, we will intensify the land struggle there," says CPI General Secretary A.B. Bardhan. Bardhan has called an emergency meeting of his party's central secretariat on August 8 to draw out an action plan for the state.

In spite of its growing closeness with TDP and despite the fact that CPI(M) cadres in the state have actively participated in the movement against Reddy's policies, CPI(M) leaders in Delhi have reacted diplomatically. They probably are aware that Congressmen would be quick to remind them about Nandigram.

All this doesn't deflect from the increasingly imperious style of functioning of the Andhra Pradesh chief minister who has adopted the strategy of attack being the best form of defence. The strategy may well boomerang and could hasten the decline of the Congress not speak of Reddy's downfall.

with Satarupa Bhattacharjya